

Female Serial Killers: Hiding in Plain Sight

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Around nine times out of ten, you see a white male's mugshot on the local news while the reporter states the amount of crimes he has caused. Most people don't think twice about it, or someone might think they look the part of a criminal. But how many times does one stop and say, where are the female career criminals? In terms of serial killers, women only make up 16.7% of the demographic and an FBI investigator went as far to say that there is no such thing as a female serial killer (Sager). Some researchers believe that women are too weak and fragile to commit multiple murders. There is a crucial link between investigation and research, and female serial killers cause a fatal disconnect. While law enforcement works towards finding suspects, female serial killers are able to hide in plain sight behind the bland assumption that they are unable to commit such a violent crime. But when we compare the gender gap in career criminality, specifically homicides, there are small correlations and large differences.

Based on biological conditions, men and women do not exactly compare when it comes to their thought process and planning behind their victims. Thinking in retrospect, it is no secret that men are considerably more violent and aggressive in nature. Considering this, male serial killers are inherently going to commit murders that are more gruesome. These career criminals are six times more likely to kill a stranger, and 65.4% of male serial killers stalk their victims (Bohn). They are hunters, and stalk their prey for their own personal pleasure and enjoyment, usually committing sexually sadistic acts against them. There are some male serial killers who have only traditionally targeted women, but also a select few who only have targeted men. Either way, their crimes are horrendous in nature and it is clear that a man committed it.

In comparison, women are biologically seen as nurturing. Meaning, they are not going to be suspected of murders due to their innocent and fragile nature. However, these women are

calculative, and frankly someone you wouldn't expect. While they are in a caregiving role, they are also educated, and more than likely married. Women are two times more likely to murder a person they already knew (Bohn); so as you see them as an innocent mother grieving the loss of a family member to a gruesome homicide, they are gathering their next victims around them. Their crimes and murders are not typically for personal enjoyment and pleasure, but for financial, power, or revenge gains.

Opportunity is one of the largest outliers between male and female career criminals. A large part is dependent on the two's routine activities. As men have been described as the hunters while women are the latter, random opportunities strike for victims of male serial killers. Most target a certain demographic, stalking and visualizing their prey, and pounce when the time is right. When the ultimate crime is committed, the victims are usually at a high exposure level meaning "...the physical visibility and accessibility of potential victims to potential offenders at any given time or place, proximity..." is very prominent (DeLisi p. 26). Darren Marchand sexually abused and murdered Stephanie Issacson, a high school girl, in early June of 1989 (DeLisi p. 23). Why? She was walking to school. Marchand took the random opportunity after seeing Issacson on her way to school, and struck. James Forte operated in the same ideals, kidnapping, sexually assaulting, and murdering 9 year old Marise Chiverella on March 18th, 1964 (DeLisi p. 22). Chiverella was simply walking to school when Forte decided it was time. It does not seem to take much, but only a few traits to commit a high level crime.

Considering women are more likely to murder someone they know, their victims do tend to be spouses, distant family members, or someone they envy due to personal reasons such as sexual assault, fraud, etc. Sharon Kinne had taken the liberty upon her to murder her affair partner's wife in lieu of her partner refusing to leave and support Kinne when she found out she

was pregnant with his child (Blaski et. al). Previously, Kinne had also been involved in a suspicious investigation into the loss of her husband, James Kinne, when he was fatally shot in the back of the head and Sharon blamed their 2-year old daughter on it. Law enforcement and investigators took Kinne's word for it, stating that she was simply too distraught to have done it. James Kinne's life insurance was awarded to her for \$200,000 dollars which is the equivalent of \$2.1 million dollars in 2024. Her crime could be seen as a financial gain, rather than a personal pleasure gain. Then, with that money, she bought a convertible and decided to begin an affair with the man she bought it from. When Kinne discovered she was pregnant with his child, she urged him to leave his wife to take care of Kinne. Upon his refusal, she became upset and lured Patricia Jones, the salesman's wife, into meeting with her where she shot and murdered her. Kinne took her opportunity to take some revenge on someone she *thought* she had wrapped around her finger.

A similar situation involved Aileen Wuornos, commonly known as the "Damsel of Death" (Biography.com). Wuornos had a very troubling childhood and was informally engaged in sex work at 11, continuing sex work throughout her life. During her toxic relationship with girlfriend Tyra Moore, Wuornos was killing men that she met during her sex work. For a total of seven men, she would have them pick her up where she would then murder them and take their car and personal belongings to pawn off on different aliases in different towns. In trial, Wuornos claimed they all sexually assaulted her, and it was in self-defense. Her admission to Moore before the trial was that she was taking revenge on the men for sexually assaulting her. Due to the gathering nature of female serial killers, they fit their victims into a categorized box in order to justify their motives based on financial, power, or revenge gain. May they take random

opportunities such as when men pick them up, or randomly calling up their victims to meet? Yes, they do. But there is always a greater motive, reasoning, and planning behind it all.

Self-control in scoping out victims plays a large part on the differences behind killing strangers and killing people that were previously known. As stated previously, men are increasingly more aggressive, violent, and likely to sexually assault their victims. Each factor plays into their low self-control. Given most male serial killers are social outliers and/or transient, which also increases the odds of having low self-control, it seems as if they simply need to satisfy their craving for sadistic murders and assaults. However, self-control has many different aspects and ways of thinking; “Self-control stratifies a society” (DeLisi p. 40). For example, Lucky Ward exhibited low levels of self-control all his life due to his prior arrests of armed robbery, aggravated assault with a deadly weapon, possession of a deadly weapon in a penal institution, and cocaine possession before his final arrest for two capital murder convictions in 2020 (DeLisi p. 43) His childhood was very violent and abusive from his parents. Meaning, his upbringing in no way fostered a sense of self-control which then in turn translated to his mid-life violence. Reasoning behind self-control can simply be of nature, not nurture however. Mr. L was born to a conventional household where by age five he showed pathological self-regulation problems. By midlife, Mr. L was very dependent on drugs and alcohol, had 80 arrest charges and 12 prison commitments, and experienced intermittent explosive disorder and antisocial personality disorder (DeLisi p. 45). Nature *and* nurture play a large part in the determinant of mental disorders, violence, and crimes.

In general, low self-control and juvenile delinquency leads to higher versatility in criminals. But for female serial killers, these factors lead to their crimes (specialized around murder) being more frequent than their peers. Women “don’t live in the same ‘fantasy world’ of

male serial killers” (Bohn). Some of the most notorious female serial killers did not have an extensive criminal history or any type of criminal arrest for that manner. Sharon Kinne was arrested once for forging checks; Aileen Wuornos had charges for assault, disturbing the peace, and disorderly conduct; Donna Perry, a transgender female serial killer charged with two murders had only previously had been arrested on multiple misdemeanor offenses (Peña), but nowhere near the severity of Lucky Ward or Mr. L. Another form of self-control revolves around how clean and organized the crime is. Men are inherently sloppy, and consistently are caught on DNA gathered from post-crime activities such as coffee cups, door handles, eaten foods, etc. Now, women are rarely ever caught on DNA charges, sometimes finger prints, but the main form is through bystanders. The presence of bystanders at crime scenes is around 60% in solved cases (DeLisi p. 29) and the rate is more than likely higher with female serial killers. Juana Barazza, known as the “Little Old Lady Killer” was no exception to the bystander rule. During her terror in Mexico, authorities were baffled by the number of elderly women being murdered and no leads. Each eyewitness said the person was masked, gloved, and looked like a man based on physical appearance. Barazza, a female wrestler in the luchador rings, was in fact muscular and taller than the average woman. So as police targeted many transgender female sex workers, which caused public outrage, Barazza continued her reign by strangling the women with articles of their clothing such as a scarf or shirt. It was not until a male relative of one of the ladies walked in on Barazza escaping the scene, where he finally got the key eyewitness account that solidified the murderer was in fact a woman (Kaplan). With normally extensive planning, female serial killers get away with their crimes easier than men depending on the time of society and the presence of bystanders.

Majorie Diehl-Armstrong is the so-called mastermind behind the murder of Brian Wells, a pizza delivery man who was murdered when a bomb collar locked onto his neck exploded after a failed attempt at robbing a bank in Erie, Wisconsin in 2003 (Palatella). With Wells was many notes outlining exact instructions for Wells' twisted manhunt for the bank, the money, and the supposed key to the bomb at the end of the line. Each section of notes also had a specialized full page of notes for the bank teller, Wells's and his behavior, and the police. This was incredibly unlike any type of robbery before. Diehl-Armstrong, previously arrested and acquitted on murder charges of her ex-boyfriend Robert Thomas, became a suspect when the Wells family revealed he had been hanging around her and her boyfriend James Roden. Unable to find Roden, they searched Diehl-Armstrong's house and found Roden murdered and stuffed in a freezer, with Diehl-Armstrong saying it was not her who killed him. After seven years of investigation (primarily due to the fact that Diehl-Armstrong was incredibly smart, but also mentally unstable and manipulative) they found out she orchestrated the entire thing, murdering Roden and Thomas. She was only charged with the death and robbery involved with Wells. Her lawyer even argued that she was too smart and manipulative to be put in the prison system and should have been institutionalized (Palatella).

Velma Barfield was a very smart individual. Educated and involved in the church, police had never suspected a thing when her mom died of a mysterious stomach illness in 1974 (Omeka RSS). In January of 1977, Barfield was in charge of the care of Mr. and Mrs. Edwards when they both died of strange stomach illnesses as well. June 1977, Barfield was caring for John Henry and Record Lee when Henry had also died of a stomach illness. Then, in late 1977, Barfield moved in with boyfriend Stuart Taylor who also passed from a stomach illness within a few months. An autopsy was never ordered on any of the victims until Taylor, which Barfield's sister

had called the cops with a suspicion that Barfield had murdered all these individuals. Barfield was arrested and confessed to each murder by poison, where she was convicted and executed by lethal injection (the first woman in the U.S. to have done so) (Schmidt). Both Barfield and Diehl-Armstrong are two great examples of the organization, planning, and covering up of crimes that female serial killers go through in order to maintain high self-control of crime scenes. As these crimes were diligently committed in the 1900s to early 2000s, technology didn't play a large role in the catching of these murderers. This is now something that is easily used more often in terms of tracking phones, social media, etc. and it is worth noting that these serial killers may not have entirely survived in this day and age, but perhaps would have gotten away with some crimes.

Male and female serial killers are entirely similar in their noncompliance pasts. Both sides have had histories of mental health disorders, arrests, and running from the police. However, it is clear that when female serial killers are caught, they are more likely to confess to their murders without the investigation providing the proper evidence. Male serial killers, usually found out to be the culprits decades later due to DNA testing, mostly will not say anything until the entirety of evidence is in front of them or a trial has found them guilty. That being said, there are plenty of female serial killers who fight their arrests. Diehl-Armstrong was diligent in making sure they continued to appeal her cases until her passing in 2018, and her blatant neglect for social and moral obligations to others during her crimes are another form of noncompliance. Sharon Kinne was entirely a different league as she was incredibly compliant in court, confessed to her crimes, and went to prison. However, she escaped five years after her commitment to prison and was never seen again. Aileen Wuornos was never compliant to societal and moral norms, being in trouble with authority figures since she was a child. During her trial, she did

confess to all her murders, but they only convicted her of six. It is rare that a criminal is remorseful of their crimes, especially serial killers, but an upwards trend of women being more remorseful than men has been seen. Velma Barfield, even with the nature of her crimes, retained her faith in the church entirely and was very active in ministry in the prison as well. Before her lethal injection, her last words were as follows: "I know that everybody has gone through a lot of pain, all the families connected, and I am sorry, and I want to thank everybody who has been supporting me all these six years." (Schmidt). Before her death, her lawyers and fellow inmates argued she was better off in a life sentence, rather than a death penalty, because of her visible remorse and her genuine ability to help other inmates.

In order to truly understand these differences and create more active predictions on "who did it?" more extensive research *needs* to be done. We live in a society where there is no longer an excuse. Female serial killers, although not as prevalent, are very easily able to get away with crimes if they continue to do it right. They are not suspected due to their biological nature, and investigators immediately tend to assume each murder is done by a man. Granted, that is right most of the time, but women cannot be counted out. There comes a time where people begin to notice the lack in proper predatory stances in law enforcement, and surely many have noticed the lack of female serial killers we know about. Many, like Juana Barazza, knew they could get away with it for as long as possible, pending they were not caught by a bystander. But what did it have to take for all to be caught? Bystanders leading the police into the situation with a leash. These women are calculative and know their perception in social situations. They are content hiding in plain sight.

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